



Epilogue

You began this book with a clear goal: to become a better manager and leader. You're mastering the "how" of leadership, but what about the "why"? Why do you care about the quality of your leadership at all? What's the ultimate purpose—and the ultimate reward—of being a good manager? Why are you investing so much energy and effort in this particular brand of self-improvement?

Some answers to these questions might be obvious to you. You want to be good at your job. You want to advance your career. You want the deep satisfaction that comes from work well done. You're competitive and you want to stand out from the crowd. Perhaps you want to fulfill your potential to be a great leader.

But the point of becoming a great leader isn't simply to *be* a great leader. It's about the impact you have on the world around you, on the people you work with and the things you produce together—those ideas, processes, connections, products, and solutions that spark growth, make the world run a bit more smoothly, or fulfill a deep need.

The extent of your influence over your direct reports may not be apparent to you. A lot of the time, you may feel as if you don't have *enough* influence. But you know from your own experience that bosses have a tremendous effect on their direct reports' lives. You spend upward of two thousand hours a year being led by your managers—talking to them, listening to them, thinking about their moods and motivations. In addition to their effect on your own productivity, output, and career, the relationship also influences who you are as a person. It can change how you relate

to your family and friends, and how you think and feel and dream, even when you're not at work. "Management is the most noble of professions if it's practiced well," says Harvard Business School professor Clay Christensen. "No other occupation offers as many ways to help others learn and grow . . . [Even d]oing deals doesn't yield the deep rewards that come from building up people."

When you invest in your growth as a leader, you begin to recognize the true power you wield in others' lives. As the months and years go by, you'll measure your success by the innovation and growth you generate for your company, and by the innovations you create that affect your industry at large. You'll find your reward in the whole ecosystem that surrounds your company's success or failure: the economic growth you help create, the customers you serve, the communities you contribute to. But you'll also be able to see the effect of your leadership on the individuals who work for you—in their professional lives, in their personal lives, and in their own successes.